# SPEAKING

WHAT RESEARCH SUGGESTS

8 beliefs. 8 evidence checks.

## THINK AGAIN.

What does the evidence say?

What can I try today?

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Simple language. Serious research.

BELIEF 01

# If I know enough English, speaking should come naturally.

**NOT ALWAYS**

### WHAT WE KNOW

Knowing English and using it quickly are different skills. Speaking needs practice, not only knowledge.

**TRY THIS**

Say one short answer aloud. Then say it again with one extra detail.

EVIDENCE: Task repetition meta-analysis, 2025; Johnson & Abdi Tabari, 2022

BELIEF 02

# Speaking improves when I practise, check how I did, plan what to improve, and try again.

## A GOOD PLAN

### WHAT WE KNOW

Research supports repeating speaking tasks, planning, and guided self-review. Checking gives you something specific to work on.

**TRY THIS**

Record 30 seconds. Listen. Choose ONE change. Try again.

EVIDENCE: Abdi Tabari et al., 2025; Huang, 2016; Liao, 2025

BELIEF 03

# If people understand me, I'm speaking well.

**PARTLY TRUE**

## WHAT WE KNOW

Being understood matters. But a clear answer can still be too short, off-topic, or missing useful detail.

**TRY THIS**

Ask: Did I answer the question? Did I explain my idea?

EVIDENCE: Communication-focused classroom application; Trofimovich et al., 2016

BELIEF 04

# Good speakers sometimes need time to think.

**YES**

## WHAT WE KNOW

Pauses are normal. Research suggests the place and length of pauses can matter more than simply having pauses.

**TRY THIS**

Pause after an idea. Then continue with a reason or example.

EVIDENCE: Tavakoli, 2011; Johnson & Abdi Tabari, 2022

BELIEF 05

# It's better to practise lots of different questions than answer the same question again.

**NOT ALWAYS**

### WHAT WE KNOW

Repeating a task can improve accuracy and sentence building. New questions are useful too: they help you use skills in new situations.

**TRY THIS**

Answer once. Improve it. Answer again. Then try a similar new question.

EVIDENCE: Abdi Tabari et al., 2025

BELIEF 06

# I need more vocabulary before I can become a better speaker.

**SOMETIMES**

### WHAT WE KNOW

New words help. But learning useful groups of words can also make speaking easier. You may already know words you do not use.

**TRY THIS**

Practise: “The thing is...” or “What I mean is...” in your own answer.

EVIDENCE: Formulaic-sequence instruction study, 2021

BELIEF 07

# Speaking confidently usually means speaking well.

**NOT NECESSARILY**

### WHAT WE KNOW

Confidence may help you start and continue. But confidence alone does not show whether an answer is clear, useful, or relevant.

**TRY THIS**

Keep your confidence. Check whether your answer really helps the listener.

EVIDENCE: Teaching inference; compare self- and listener-ratings: Trofimovich et al., 2016

BELIEF 08

# When I'm speaking, I usually know how good my speaking is.

**NOT ALWAYS**

### WHAT WE KNOW

In one study, some weaker speakers rated themselves too highly; some stronger speakers rated themselves too low.

**TRY THIS**

Predict how you did. Listen back. Compare your prediction with what you hear.

EVIDENCE: Trofimovich et al., 2016; Huang, 2016

# RESEARCH BEHIND THE SLIDES

**Task repetition in speaking (2025)**
doi.org/10.1016/j.system.2025.103868

**Planning before speaking (2022)**
doi.org/10.1093/applin/amac026

**Pauses in second-language speech (2011)**
doi.org/10.1093/elt/ccq020

**Useful word groups and fluency (2021)**
doi.org/10.1016/j.lingua.2021.103072

**Self-assessment accuracy (2016)**
doi.org/10.1017/S1366728914000832

**Listening to your own speech (2016)**
doi.org/10.1080/02602938.2015.1042426

**Self-review and speaking progress (2025)**
nature.com/articles/s41599-025-05674-2

*Some statements are teaching interpretations, not direct claims tested by one study.*